

Openness & Compersion:

Preliminary Project Examining the Association Between Openness and Compersion in Consensually Nonmonogamous Romantic Relationships

Wenlan Pan, Rose Bern & Paul Eastwick

The Attraction and Relationships Research Lab, University of California, Davis



Background

- ❖ Openness:
 - Openness is one of the dimensions of the Big-5 personality scale which captures the vividness of imagination, examining how individuals “immerse themselves in a task [to] fully comprehend an area of interest” [McCrae, 1996].
 - Earlier research found that:
 - People with high levels of openness are more likely to reach positive resolutions during conflict with their partners [Park & Antonioni, 2007].
 - People who score high in openness are more prone to engage in CNM [Moors, 2017].
 - Openness is negatively correlated with relationship quality in monogamous relationships, which may be related to the positive association between openness and engagement in infidelity [Dyrenforth et al., 2010].
- ❖ Compersion:
 - CNM is a relationship style where all partners have mutually agreed to have multiple sexual and/or intimate romantic relationships at the same time (e.g., open relationships, swinging, polyamory, etc.).
 - Compersion is widely used among consensually nonmonogamous (CNM) individuals to refer to the positive emotion a person experiences in response to their partner's intimate experiences with another partner (i.e., metamour), which contrasts jealousy [Flicker et al., 2021]. Compersion is conceptualized across three categories: sexual arousal, excitement for new connections, and happiness about partner/metamour relationship.
 - Prior research has found that CNM folks report lower levels of jealousy and higher levels of compersion than their monogamous counterparts [Flicker et al., 2022; Aumer et al., 2014; Mogilski et al., 2019].
- ❖ Little is known about the mechanism of compersion but prior studies have found that jealousy is positively associated with relationship satisfaction in monogamous relationships while compersion is positively correlated with relationship satisfaction in non-traditional relationships. [Aumer et al., 2014].
- ❖ While prior research found a negative association between compersion and neuroticism [Flicker et al., 2021], no research has examined the connection between compersion and openness. Given that these constructs predict key relationship outcomes, we need to better understand their association in this understudied sample.

Research Question

What is the relationship between compersion and openness in consensually nonmonogamous individuals?

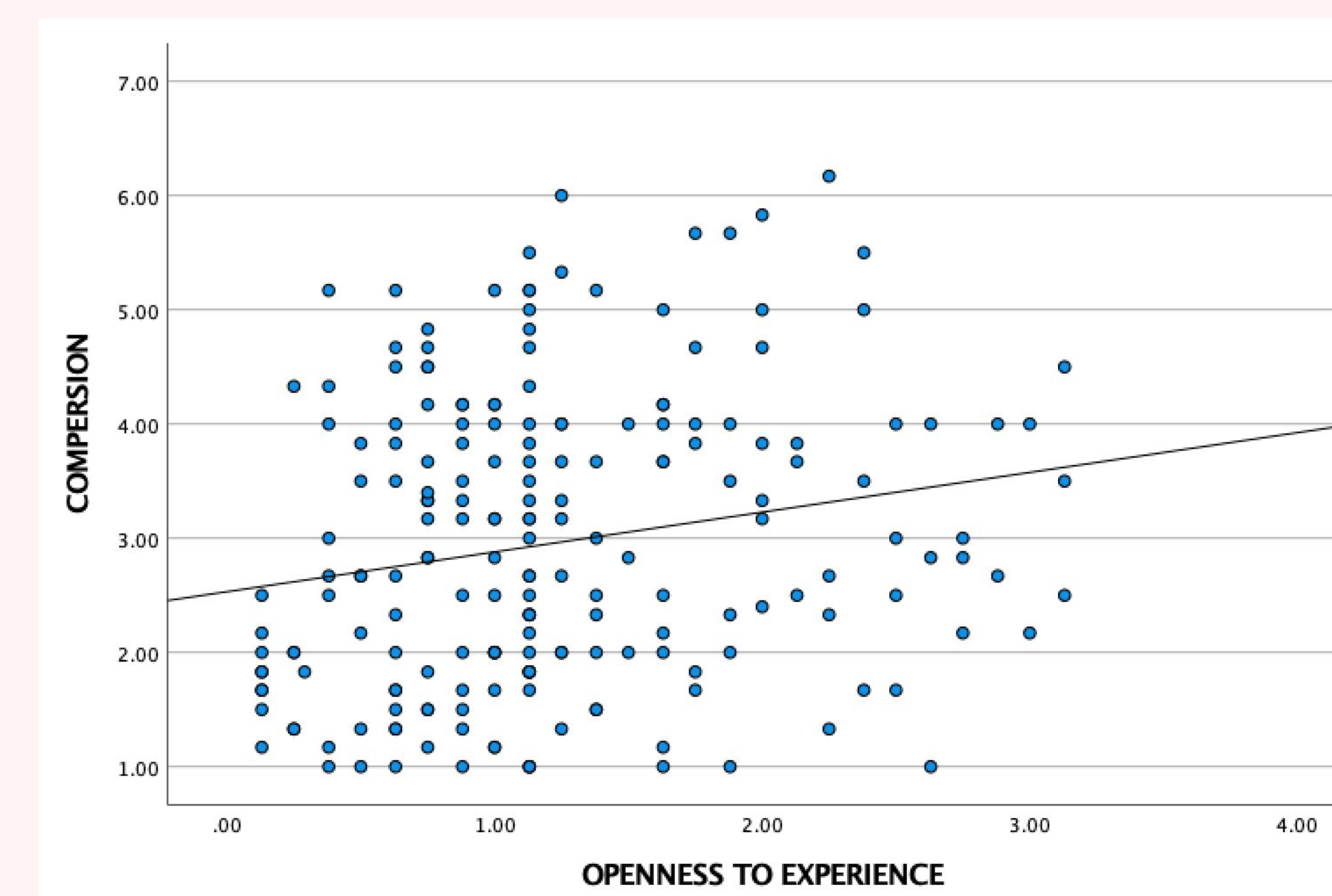
Hypothesis

We expect that openness to experience will weakly positively correlate with compersion across CNM individuals. We will test this hypothesis using bivariate Pearson's correlation.

Methods

- SONA survey of UC Davis college students ($n=72$) who must currently be in or have previously been in a CNM relationship (e.g., open relationship, friends with benefits, swinging, polyamory, etc.)
- **IV: Openness to experience**
 - Big-5 Mini IPIP Shortened scale e.g., “I have a vivid imagination.” [Donnellan et al., 2006]
- **DV: Compersion**
 - COMPERSe scale was used to capture compersion e.g., “I’m excited when my partner is talking to a potential hookup” [Flicker et al., 2021]

Preliminary Result



- If the hypothesis is confirmed then individuals who report higher scores for openness to experience will also generally report higher scores for compersion. As openness increases, compersion will too.
- This scatter plot depicts a hypothetical weak positive correlation ($r=.2$) between these constructs.

Discussion

Limitations:

1. The majority of the participants are heterosexual, cisgender men and women who reported they were casually dating and/or in a friends with benefits relationship. Additionally, the participants are all students at UC Davis between the ages of 18-22.
2. This sample has a small n and thus, it may not be able to detect significant effect sizes that are generalizable to CNM populations.

Future Directions:

1. Examine how relationship type (e.g. swinging, open relationship, and etc.) might moderate the association between openness to experience and compersion.
2. Examine whether number of partners might predict compersion and how compersion levels vary across partners.

Acknowledgements

Thank you to Dr. Paul Eastwick and Rose Bern at the Attraction and Relationships Research Laboratory, and Dr. Steven Luck, Michaela DeBolt, Erie Boorman, and the entire ASPIRE team.